

Reading the Housing Record

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A deed amount, a financing label and a tax liability look like simple facts, but each comes out of a legal or administrative process built for purposes other than measurement. These papers ask what New York City's public housing records measure and how tax rules shape the sales they record. All use free city records, and each has a public replication archive. Site: pgold30.github.io/reading-the-housing-record.

01 · DEED AMOUNTS

Version 1.0.4

When a Deed Is Not a Market Sale

When does recorded consideration follow a legal rule rather than a negotiated price, and what does that do to a price index?

Of 1.47 million deeds recorded in 2003–2025, 16,655 are labelled legal-rule transfers, such as a referee's deed to the foreclosing lender. 70% of their amounts carry cents, against 6% of ordinary sales, yet conventional screens keep them, and 94–95% of those recorded in 2016–2025 appear in the city's sales file at the recorded amount. Removing them changes the path of a repeat-sales index more than its total decline (a 0.6 log-point difference, interval -3.0 to $+1.2$). In a document review of 400 sampled deeds, 99.3% of flagged deeds are non-market and the classifier finds 96.6% of foreclosure transfers; dropping only the narrowest third still moves the index by 2.6 points.

Concept DOI 10.5281/zenodo.22925383

02 · FINANCING LABELS

Version 3.4

Who Gets the House?

Does a recorded cash–mortgage price gap reflect financing, or who buys with cash?

Financed purchases of the same house sell 9.25 log points above cash purchases (95% interval 7.17–11.35). Excluding the 358 pairs with a same-surname deed, a marker of possible transfers between relatives, roughly halves the gap, to 4.87 (2.69–6.76), and when the cash buyer is a company the gap is 1.53, with an interval that includes zero. A document review of 53 sampled pairs confirms 54 of 56 financed labels; dropping the 4 pairs with a documented error leaves 9.40, and a stress test for unseen errors keeps it between 9.1 and 9.3. These are associations in linked records, not effects of financing.

Concept DOI 10.5281/zenodo.22421850

03 · TAX DESIGN

Preprint 2.5 · replication 1.8

The Shape of the Tax

How did sales shift at the transfer-tax notches created in 2019, and what does that mean for taxing borrowers and cash buyers differently?

At each new threshold with enough sales, sales moved to just below it: 4 sales at \$1,999,999 from January 2016 to March 2019, 131 since the \$2 million notch took effect. Each response is larger than at any of sixteen never-taxed round prices and starts with the reform, and most of it comes from resales. Bunching costs \$2–3 million a year in avoided tax, 2–3% of what the new taxes raise between \$2 and \$6 million. The city's mortgage recording tax charges borrowers 1.41% of price for houses and 1.28% for condominiums and cash buyers nothing; with transactions held fixed, it raises about \$244 million a year on residential purchase money in four boroughs. The paper identifies neither incidence nor an optimal tax.

Concept DOI 10.5281/zenodo.22925301

04 · THEORY · SIMULATION

Version 6.0

The Execution-Certainty Wedge

If a buyer's certainty of closing can decide who gets a home, how would one tell which policy widens access at the lowest cost?

In a simulated market, the ranking of acquisition caps, fair-share quotas, constant charges and contention-triggered duties depends on how access and efficiency are measured. A benchmark computed over buyers still waiting moves with the policy and can reverse the sign of its effect, and counting access over the whole run understates a cohort's gains by up to 2.5 times. The comparison is conditional and uncalibrated.

Concept DOI 10.5281/zenodo.22164073

Data · PUBLIC DATASET

Version 1.0

NYC sales linked to deeds and mortgages, 2016–2025

The shared record behind the empirical papers, published so others can use it.

All 729,047 house, condominium and co-operative sales of 2016–2025, with 277,298 house and condominium sales linked to a unique deed, 188,076 with a recorded purchase mortgage and its amount, and flags for company buyers, shared surnames, shared addresses and lender take-title deeds. For condominiums it recovers the unit lot that the sales file hides. It reproduces the tax paper's recording-tax statistics exactly, and its financing flags for all but 4 of 249,084 purchases. No party names. CC BY 4.0, with codebook, raw extracts and code.

Concept DOI 10.5281/zenodo.22977532

How the records were checked. The deed and house papers report document reviews of probability samples (400 deeds; 53 repeat-sale pairs). The original protocols called for two human readers; these versions use AI instead: ChatGPT read the images and Claude then checked every reading against the city's open data. The results measure agreement with those readings, not accuracy against a verified record. Answer keys were opened only after the readings were locked. The tax paper's calculations do not depend on these reviews.